Honorification in Korean: Some Evidence for a Pragmatic Account

Introduction. Korean is one of many languages that employs a system of honorification by means of morphosyntax to indicate the social standing of discourse participants. Here we focus on the verbal marker *-si-* (see Cho (2022) for an overview of honorification in Korean), which has traditionally been understood as a 'subject honorific' that honors the subject of the verb it attaches to, as exemplified in (1). In (1), we observe the subject *Kim sensayngnim* 'teacher Kim' honored by two different ways: (1) the use of the suffix *-nim* attached directly to it, and (2) the verbal suffix *-si-* on the verb. In generative accounts, the prevailing view has been to treat the presence or absence of *-si-* as a form of syntactic agreement (Choe, 2004); however, it has also been argued to express a kind of social meaning (Potts & Kawahara, 2004; Kim & Sells, 2007). We present experimental evidence in support of the latter pragmatic view of *-si-*. We conducted a forced-choice experiment exploring whether listeners draw inferences about the speaker's endorsement of the event described based on the presence of *-si-*. If the use of the marker is purely syntactic, then it should not provide evidence of the speaker's attitude towards the subject or their action. On the other hand, if honorification is a pragmatic phenomenon, then listeners might draw inferences about the speaker's attitudes based on their choice to use or not use *-si-*.

Method. Stimuli were simple sentences containing a noun and verb with different perceived social connotations: positive, negative, or neutral, e.g., 'president', 'gangster', 'neighbor' for subjects; and 'donate', 'embezzle', 'walk' for verbs. Our stimuli comprised every combination of subject-verb pairs, e.g., +subj-+verb, -subj-+verb, etc. For each subject-verb pair, two versions were generated (one with -(u)si and one without). An additional Subject condition was created to account for subjects that usually co-occur with the noun honorification marker *-nim*, e.g., teacher, *sensayng**nim*** .We ensured that participants saw only one variation of each subject-verb pair during trials. Each stimulus was formatted as an utterance by a speaker, and participants were asked to say whether they thought the speaker expressed respect toward the grammatical subject, a binary choice between YES and NO (Fig. 2). Participants (N = 34) were adult native Korean speakers ($mean_{years}$ = 46.93; sd_{years} = 13.11).

Results. Our results provide evidence towards a pragmatic view of honorification (Fig. 1). First, in the non-marked verb conditions, we find that participants give higher respect ratings for neutral subjects (23.2%) than for subjects that usually occur with a noun honorific (8.1%) ($t(523.2) = 5.2$, $p < 0.001$). This suggests that participants reason about why the speaker might have omitted the honorific. Second, we find that the presence of a verb honorific marker significantly increases respect ratings (from 19.6% to 62.5%) regardless of whether the subject or action is ordinarily seen as honorable ($t(2355.7) = -24.0$, $p < 0.001$). This suggests that participants interpret the presence of the verb honorific as conveying information about the speaker's attitude. While verbs (14.4%) and subjects (15.6%) in the negative valence condition typically receive low respect ratings, the use of a verb honorific marker shifts the participant's perception of the speaker's attitudes, resulting in respect ratings that approach 50% for negative valence subjects with verb honorification (51.9%, $t(557.4) = -10.3$, $p < 0.001$) and negative valence verbs with honorification (48.5%, $t(731.0) = -11.2$, $p < 0.001$). Our experiment does not directly address the grammaticality of these conditions; however, in their debriefing comments, no participants noted grammaticality issues. Taken together, our findings provide preliminary evidence of a pragmatic relationship between speaker respect and honorification.

(1) Kim sensayng-nim-i o-si-ess-ta
Kim teacher-HON-SUBJ come-si-PST-DECL.PLAIN
'Teacher Kim came'.

Figure 1. Example of a trial. Participants are asked whether they think the speaker of the utterance (*Minho*) respects the grammatical subject (*Priest*) in the utterance: '*The priest studied'.*

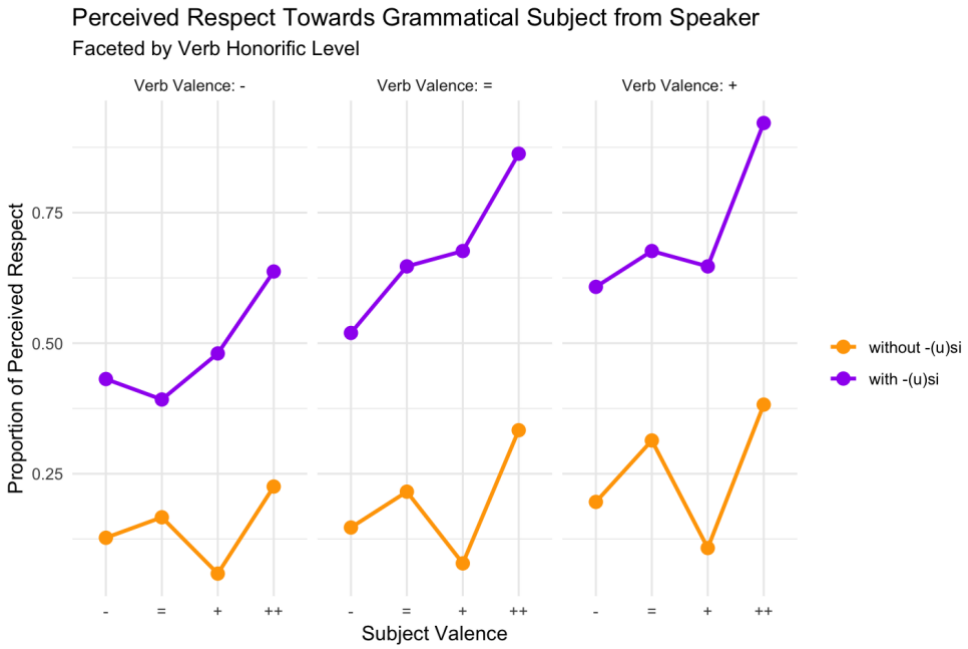

Figure 2. Participant responses plotted across different subject and verb valences, with ++ for subjects typically co-occurring with the honorific marker *-nim-*, for both conditions (with or without the subject honorific marker *-si-*.

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